

REAL-TIME MONITORING OF HIS MANY SCHEMES AND ENSURING ADHERENCE TO TIMELINES HAS BEEN THE HALLMARK OF MODI'S PRIME MINISTERSHIP

authoritarian and accuses him of unleashing central investigation agencies like the Enforcement Directorate and the Central Bureau of Investigation with trumped-up charges to neutralise opponents. Modi has to stay the course on reforms if his party is to win a full majority in the 2024 general election and he is to become prime minister for the third consecutive term—a feat only Nehru has accomplished thus far.

Meanwhile, Modi's style of leadership has become the subject of study in management circles. At the Indian Institute of Management, Bangalore, Ekkirala S. Srinivas, professor of organisational behaviour and HR Management, and an expert on leadership, points out that Modi's success lies in his extraordinary ability to establish a direct connect with people across different segments of society, speak in their language and highlight their issues. So when he goes to Varanasi, his constituency, for instance, he makes it a point to invoke Ganga *maiyya*, saying he is there at her behest, and when he lands up in Madanapalli in Andhra Pradesh soon after, he addresses the issues of tomato farmers there. He does not require the media or other intermediaries to strike a chord with the voter; he uses Mann Ki Baat as a major vehicle. "Modi appeals to their identity in a very rare, unique and powerful way," says Srinivas. "If you touch identity and invoke pride, you evoke powerful emotions as he does."

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Union minister Piyush Goyal, who has worked closely with Modi, also attributes his success to "the extraordinary empathy the prime minister has with the common man and the fact that despite reaching the pinnacle of success, he has never forgotten his humble past". The affable Goyal, an alumnus of the Harvard Business School, says what strikes him about Modi is his single-minded focus on the job at hand and complete lack of interest in taking vacations, having fun or shooting the breeze. Goyal once asked Modi whether he enjoyed eating food. His reply? "I eat to live, not live to eat." The minister finds in Modi an almost yogic quality of remaining totally in the moment, engaging intensely and not getting distracted by the thousands of other tasks he may have to attend to. What has been disconcerting for Goyal on many occasions is the prime minister's almost photographic memory. You will never find him with pen and paper at meetings, yet there have been several occasions when Goyal has made a 50-slide presentation and Modi has asked him to go back to a particular slide and explain why it is out of sync with the overall theme. In cabinet meetings, rather than hold forth himself, Modi relies on the group dynamic and encourages ministers to speak their mind while ensuring the discussions remain inclusive and participative to enable him to reach a considered decision. When it comes to follow-up and accountability, Modi is CEO-like in monitoring tasks and ensuring adherence to timelines.

Srinivas places Modi in the league of transformational leaders who are characterised more by charisma and exceptional articulation. His way of framing the narrative involves talking of the larger vision and using his personal example of probity and humble beginnings, which never fails to evoke admiration among the masses. "Modi enjoys a heroic charismatic image with an instant connect," he concludes. Even if he errs, he is able to convince people that his intentions are well-meaning and everything he does is for the greater good and not for personal advancement. What Srinivas would caution against is what he terms "the dark side of charisma that can afflict the best of leaders". With celebrity status, he warns, can come insecurity. "The ego intrudes and demands unquestioned loyalty as well as an arrogance that ends up as an 'I know best' attitude. Every leader needs to be aware of this and not fall into that trap," he says. Modi, Srinivas believes, should be aware of these and constantly fine-tune his actions to retain the trust of the nation. More so as a third term beckons and he appears to be in pole position to win it. If he does win a third term, it will give him the opportunity to stand on the same pedestal as Nehru who, despite his flaws, is the statesman every political leader aspires to emulate. ■